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BRICS and transnational capitalism

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The BRICS (Brazil, Russia, India, China and South Africa) countries are what world-systems and other theorists refer to as semi-peripheral countries, or countries that occupy an intermediary position between core and peripheral states within a world hierarchy of nation-states, and are presumably attempting to move up in this hierarchy into the core. The BRICS came together as a group in 2006, have held regular summits since 2009, and exercise growing political and economic clout in the international system.

Nonetheless, a fundamental distinction we want to make in the social sciences, one essential to understanding global capitalism, is between surface phenomena and underlying essence. We must move from the surface-level dynamics of interstate political relations in order to get at the underlying meaning of G7/BRICS dynamics. We must not overemphasise political jockeying in the arena of international relations. The relationship between politics and economics is complex. Latin American Marxists have understood a number of left-populist revolutions in that region in the 1960s and the 1970s, such as that led by Juan Velasco Alvarado in Peru in 1968, less as anti-capitalist challenges than as movements to bring about more modern class relations in the face of the tenacity of the antiquated, often semi-feudal oligarchies, and thus to renovate and free up capitalism from atavistic constraints on its full development.

In a similar way, the BRICS politics aim to force those elites from the older centres of world capitalism into a more balanced and integrated global capitalism. China repeatedly proposed in the wake of the 2008 collapse not that the yuan become the new world currency but that the IMF issue a truly world currency